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What does it take for a Film to be Considered a Success?



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Everyone probably has different opinions on what might make a movie successful. The average movie goer might see a movie is performing well financially and believe it is a success. I am sure it is the case for the studio as well, but other people have different opinions. I myself think there are more factors playing into success in film, and I am sure you do not see the earnings as the sole factor of success. Artistry and filmmaking achievements might stand out more to different crowds, giving other definitions for what success is; so, which definition is the most substantial? How does one factor's impact compare to another's? In my eyes, they go hand in hand, but some factors have more value than others, and I would like to know which ones, and if it aligns with my beliefs. .

A good starting point is glossing over the audience roles in movies. You have the studio, who owns the film and looks to make profit from it. There are the filmmakers and performers in the movie, doing their best to display their

own talents, getting paid in the process. There are critics, who see the films first, and judge them accordingly. Lastly the general public, who are going to the movies, giving these studios profit, and are also the ones reacting to the critics opinions. There are lots of other roles, but I feel those are the big catch-alls. One of the other roles, a sub-group of the studio, are advertisers and marketers, who are looking to draw audiences in. If marketers are given the opportunity to spend high amounts on promotion, it is found the revenues of the movie early on are enhanced. In the same study this was found, it discovered how early on movie revenues also amplify its subsequent movie ratings, which shows the importance of marketers. With a positive amount of money early-on, audience reactions are improving, indicating more often than not, more money spent on advertising leads to financial and critical success. (Moon, Sangkil, et al).

This concept is interesting, as in my own experience, I have had mixed feelings about too much advertising. I would end up seeing trailers countless times in the movie theater, because their promotions would start so early on. I remember getting annoyed and disinterested in *Top Gun: Maverick* because of seeing Tom Cruise's face every time I sat in a movie theater; despite this, after a year of watching previews, I thoroughly enjoyed the movie. This supports the claim of high marketing budgets allowing for both great critical and financial performances, as *Top Gun: Maverick* was a box-office winner from memorial day to labor day. However, if someone is drawn away because of too much marketing, more often than not they simply will not see it. A recent example for me was *One Battle After Another*. For clarification, I was looking forward to this movie for years before it released, but once trailers started dropping and they were putting characters in fortnite, a friend told me "I bet that is going to suck," simply because he saw too much advertisement and had no other knowledge. In my point of view, marketing

can be a contributor to the success of a film, but can also draw people away, it all depends on who is in the audience.

With the knowledge of how a film's performance is dependent on how it opens financially, I want to examine the sequels, as they could second the idea, or conflict with it and provide an opposing viewpoint to what makes them a success. I could see this going both ways, as some sequels build on the earnings of the original, and some simply ruin the reputation of its predecessor. Films like *The Dark Knight* or the aforementioned *Top Gun: Maverick* are rare, turning out better both critically and financially, but it does happen. On the contrary, you are likely to get unwanted sequels, tarnishing what the first had built on, like the recent *Ghostbusters* material. Personally, I enjoy a sequel when it is needed, but I despise when the story has wrapped up and they continue it with needless garbage. It is found the performances of sequels typically rely on if the original film had performed well financially, as there is an indication of potential commercial success of a sequel; also, if the parent movie had positive ratings, and no financial win, the performances of the sequel are unaffected. This reveals the reactions of the critics and audiences for sequels do not matter financially, and if the original film makes enough money, people are going to see the follow-up. This further solidifies the claim about success rooting in financial performances, continuing its case of being the most important part of a movie's success (H. Yong, W. Tie-nan and L. Xiang-yang).

Box-office success is huge, and is something studios look at when deciding what to do going forward; but, another important aspect of success, one which may be more important to some, is how well a film is made. What inside the movie makes some of the greatest movies ever considered "cinematic achievements?" First off, we should know what should be analyzed in a movie and how we can determine if what it is doing is

beneficial. It is necessary to notice what a film's purpose is, as it can help determine our emotions towards it. Do we have conflicting ideologies to what they're portraying, and can we respect those opinions? Do we agree with them? Then, there is the importance of the dynamics, because if their message isn't properly presented, then the content is going to get lost within the creation. These dynamics can break barriers, and filmmakers can be successful in doing things never done before. In Godard's *Breathless* (1960), his techniques and style, with the introduction of jump cuts and attempts at non-linear narratives, influence generations of filmmaking around the world. Even if people do not love the movie, the all-around influence can be considered a success. Adding onto purpose and dynamics, how the film is used also begs examination. Films are made with a particular audience in mind, and people are then able to discuss them, and how they are discussed can indicate success as well (Linden, Kathry). How much these aspects matter to you is subjective, but audiences are going to form their own opinions; even if a film is making profit, people will still express disappointment.

Lots of films where its successes are based on the creation get their flowers from different awards across the world. Most of these awards are disagreeable, but I would argue a lot of the great films are recognized, which is a success in its own right. A great example of success without a good financial performance is Frank Capra's *It's a Wonderful Life*, which flopped in its original theatrical run, but collected five academy award nominations, even one for best picture, and is now hailed as a timeless Christmas classic (Fun Facts, Commonplace). Good films are bound to get their props eventually, and audiences will see this success if they pay close attention.

With this in mind, are we able to consider a movie as a success, even if it does not even make a profit? I think this can be determined by the amount

of people who are actually interested in the filmmaking of a film. In regards to what audiences pay more attention to, whether it be the writing, music, or camerawork, is totally subjective to what viewers value more. Some like the narrative elements, analyzing plot and character development, discovering how the film leaves an emotional impact on the audience; others value the technical aspects, as if the story is not precisely put to screen with the right amount of craftsmanship, the story will not hit the same way (Alex).

Personally, I am into the narrative elements, as I like seeing how characters might change and possible symbolism throughout a film. This might root from my enjoyment of reading, so someone else might be more interested in how a frame is shot or how sets are crafted.

Considering all filmmaking aspects essentially go hand in hand, we remind ourselves that high initial reviews from these reviewers lead to high opening performances financially. This reveals to us the importance of the quality of the film, and how the quality is going to lead to financial success. Reviewers have to believe it is well-made for audiences to want to go see it. Sure, there will be outliers, but most people are going to the movies to see a movie they heard good things about. This is leading to success both for the filmmaker and in the monetary aspect. So the success of the filmmaking ultimately leads to the success of the film.

We can take these factors into consideration now to decide, what is the most successful film ever? We know our criteria: High-caliber or innovative filmmaking, reviewers speak highly of it, made lots of money, and audiences enjoyed it as well. The best way to start narrowing this down is by examining what movies are considered to be the greatest movies ever, and then checking out their box-office statistics to determine what was the most successful, both critically and financially.

I am going to include multiple different sources to get different viewpoints on what they feel are the greatest movies ever, and then analyze how they performed financially, to see what are the biggest successes of the bunch. My sources are going to include the Sight and Sound top 250, which has polled critics on their opinions since 1952, the Empire top 100, which is a combination of readers and critics, and letterboxd's top 250 narrative features list, which is the culmination of the ratings of everyone on the site. I will find what movies appear on all 3 lists, and see where they are placed on each of them.

Films:

The Godfather (1972)

Sight and Sound: 12

Empire: 3

Letterboxd: 15

Apocalypse Now (1979)

Sight and Sound: 19

Empire: 29

Letterboxd: 36

Seven Samurai (1954)

Sight and Sound: 20

Empire: 65

Letterboxd: 5

Goodfellas (1990)

Sight and Sound: 64

Empire: 10

Letterboxd: 30

Parasite (2019)

Sight and Sound: 93

Empire: 18

Letterboxd: 12

The Godfather Part 2 (1974)

Sight and Sound: 104

Empire: 14

Letterboxd: 7

Do the Right Thing (1989)

Sight and Sound: 24

Empire: 47

Letterboxd: 57

The Thing (1982)

Sight and Sound: 118

Empire: 32

Letterboxd: 101

Spirited Away (2001)

Sight and Sound: 77

Empire: 49

Letterboxd: 32

In the Mood for Love (2000)

Sight and Sound: 5

Empire: 78

Letterboxd: 77

Portrait of a Lady on Fire (2019)

Sight and Sound: 30

Empire: 93

Letterboxd: 48

Singin' in the Rain (1952)

Sight and Sound: 10

Empire: 67

Letterboxd: 110

There Will Be Blood (2007)

Sight and Sound: 122

Empire: 43

Letterboxd: 29

Rear Window (1954)

Sight and Sound: 40

Empire: 72

Letterboxd: 91

The Good, the Bad and the Ugly (1966)

Sight and Sound: 169

Empire: 38

Letterboxd: 19

It's a Wonderful Life (1946)

Sight and Sound: 133

Empire: 44

Letterboxd: 53

2001: A Space Odyssey (1968)

Sight and Sound: 6

Empire: 23

Letterboxd: 207

Psycho (1960)

Sight and Sound: 33

Empire: 81

Letterboxd: 144

Lawrence of Arabia (1962)

Sight and Sound: 133

Empire: 62

Letterboxd: 70



Casablanca (1942)

Sight and Sound: 63

Empire: 33

Letterboxd: 185

Mulholland Drive (2001)

Sight and Sound: 8

Empire: 73

Letterboxd: 214

Pulp Fiction (1994)

Sight and Sound: 129

Empire: 7

Letterboxd: 225

Heat (1995)

Sight and Sound: 169

Empire: 30

Letterboxd: 162

Alien (1979)

Open in app ↗



Empire: 21

Letterboxd: 222

It is understandable to claim these rankings do not matter, and I myself, do not really pay attention to them. I form my own opinions, and I never let any of these lists impact it; with that being said, it is not like these lists do not have weight. The fact these films are on all three of the lists, lists audiences read and then go out to watch the “greatest movies ever”, and they still appear on all three of them after more opinions are formed, indicates we can reliably call these some of the greatest movies ever. *The Godfather* having the best overall ratings does not come as a surprise, as if you were to ask someone what they think the greatest movie ever made is, it would be the general consensus more often than not. I have seen most of these movies, and my favorites are *Mulholland Drive* and *Spirited Away*, but I cannot argue with *The Godfather* being number one.

Do these standings correlate with the financial success of the movie? I am sure there are different circumstances for each, as maybe some flopped and became a classic over time, while others boomed off the bat; but we are looking at the profit they made, as it is what will help see their successes. I will be basing their return on investment (ROI), to find the return from each film, as this way we can see how well these films were working with what they had to spend.

After doing the statistics, we are able to see how many times its original budget these films earned. We see Hitchcock's *Psycho*, which had an original budget of around 800k, made around 62 times that amount, meaning it was the biggest financial success of the group. Following it, other financial successes include *The Godfather* (45x), *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* (31.6x), and another Hitchcock film, *Rear Window* (27.6x).

Films by ROI (Earning/Budget)

Psycho (1960): ~61.9

The Godfather (1972): ~45

The Good, the Bad and the Ugly (1966): ~31.6

Rear Window (1954): ~27.6

Pulp Fiction (1994): ~23.5

Spirited Away (2001): ~20.8

Parasite (2019): ~14.4

Casablanca (1942): ~9.8

Alien (1979): ~9.5

Heat (1995): ~6.2

2001: A Space Odyssey (1968): ~5.9

In the Mood for Love (2000): ~4.6

Lawrence of Arabia (1962): ~4.6

The Godfather Part 2 (1974): ~4.4

Do the Right Thing (1989): ~4

There Will Be Blood (2007): ~3.1

Singin' in the Rain (1952): ~2.9

Seven Samurai (1954): ~2.8

Apocalypse Now (1979): ~2.7

Portrait of a Lady on Fire (2019): ~1.9

Mulholland Drive (2001): ~1.4

Goodfellas (1990): ~1

The Thing (1982): ~1

It's a Wonderful Life (1946): ~0.89

Despite these movies being classics, the majority of them did not perform so well, or they flopped entirely. Films like *Goodfellas* and *The Thing*, that placed highly on the critical acclaim list, found themselves flopping at their original box-offices and at the bottom of this list. It is interesting examining how well these great films did at the box-office, because a lot of great films did not perform well. Obviously, there are countless amounts of films out there so the previous statements about financial return depending on strong opening reviews still stand, but lots of these are films I would have imagined to do well.

When determining what films have the best combined critic score and box-office score, we must look at the top of each list, where *The Godfather* stands

alone as easily the most successful of the bunch. To my surprise, Bong Joon Ho's 2019 film *Parasite* is a film with the next-best score, and then titles such as *Spirited Away*, *Rear Window*, and *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* following those up. With this, we can conclude these movies, with the standards which were previously determined, to be the most successful of all time. Their combination of critical and audience appreciation, along with their financial gain put them ahead of the rest.

To clarify once again, this was done simply to find as objective of an answer as possible, and in reality, all of this is subjective. Sure, I love *The Godfather* and the other films mentioned, but most of my favorites do not even fall on this list; and I am sure most of yours do not either, which is perfectly okay. These are simply the ones falling under the criteria we found to be a success: critical acclaim, well-made, and box-office success. It may not be a criteria most follow, even myself, but from a non-biased point of view, those are the characteristics of a successful film.

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